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REPORT

EU-WBF JOINT ACTION

FIRST CALL FOR REGIONAL PROJECTS

www.westernbalkansfund.org

PROJECT NAME:

**SUPPORT TO THE PROMOTION OF CIVIL SOCIETY
REGIONAL ACTIONS IN THE WESTERN BALKANS
CN 2021/424-879**

JULY 2023



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About the Report

The WBF/EU Joint Action Report by the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) represents a notable milestone in the action's progress. This report encompasses the period of the grant scheme implementation. The grant scheme implementation was launched with a Call for Proposal that was open in November 2021 and extended until the first months of 2023. Moreover, this Report offers a comprehensive analysis of the activities, achievements, challenges, and impact of the joint action highlighting the efforts made by the WBF to foster regional cooperation, promote people-to-people exchange, and support projects that contribute to the social, cultural, and economic development of the Western Balkans.

Key Milestones and Achievements

WBF/EU Joint Action Report, outlines the successful initiation of the grant scheme support to third parties, which served as a catalyst for regional actors to implement regional actions in line with the WBF's objectives. The grant scheme aimed to strengthen regional cooperation, enhance cultural exchange, and promote sustainable development in the Western Balkans.

Project Proposal Application and Evaluation, provides insights into the rigorous evaluation process employed by the WBF to identify high-quality project proposals. It emphasizes the organization's commitment to transparency, fairness, and adherence to predefined criteria during the selection process.

Project Implementation presents the overview of the awarded regional projects within the framework of 4th Call for Proposals. It highlights the diverse range of initiatives, including those focused on youth empowerment, educational exchange, cultural heritage preservation, environmental sustainability, and economic cooperation. The report showcases the impact of these projects on regional integration, social cohesion, and cross-border collaboration.

Regional Cooperation and Networking, focuses on the WBF's role as a facilitator of regional cooperation by bringing together individuals, organizations, and institutions from different Western Balkan CPs. It highlights the networking opportunities provided by the funded projects, enabling stakeholders to exchange knowledge, experiences, and best practices.

Challenges and Lessons Learned, acknowledges the challenges faced during the implementation phase of the 4th Call for Proposals. It discusses the lessons learned and the WBF's commitment to continuously improve its processes, address potential obstacles, and enhance the impact of its initiatives in the future.

Conclusion and Future Plans, encapsulates the organization's dedication to promoting regional cooperation, fostering development, and strengthening the bonds among Western Balkan Contracting Parties. By adopting a numbering convention for future reports, the WBF aims to provide clarity and continuity in its publications, allowing stakeholders to track its progress and impact over time.

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How did we get here?



EU-Western Balkans Leaders' Sofia Summit of 2018, dedicated to WB Region European perspective, development and cooperation, adopted a Declaration confirming EU's support for the region's European perspective.

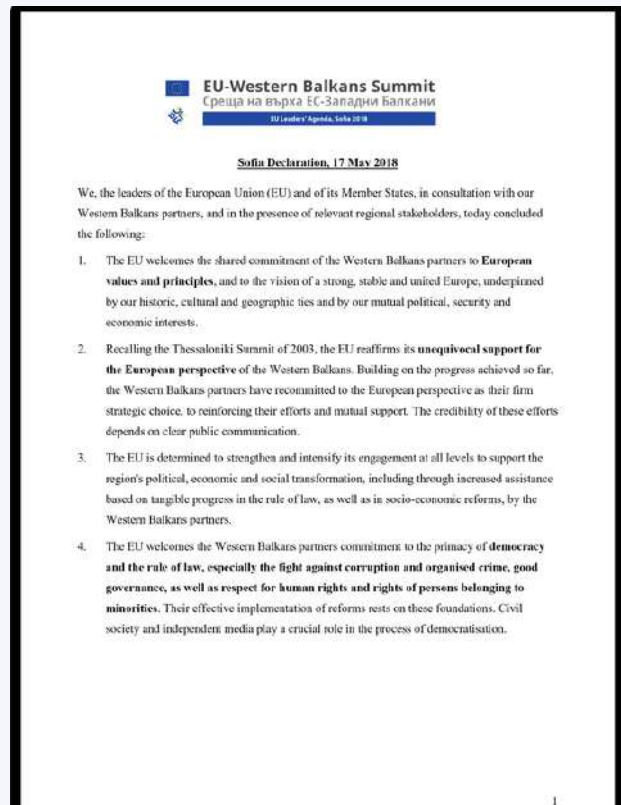
The Sofia Declaration was a significant milestone in the regional cooperation efforts of the Western Balkan contracting parties. In May 2018 at the European Union – Western Balkans Summit took place in Bulgaria. The Sofia Declaration deriving from this Summit aimed to strengthen the ties between the European Union and the Western Balkans and promote regional cooperation among the Western Balkan contracting parties themselves. One of the key outcomes of the Sofia Summit was the support given towards the Western Balkans Fund as a regional mechanism to support people-to-people connections and foster cooperation in the Western Balkans region.

More specifically, the leaders of the European Union and of its Member States, in consultation with Western Balkans partners, and in the presence of relevant regional stakeholders, concluded the following:

“

Supporting reconciliation and good neighbourly relations in the Western Balkans; more specifically promote deepening of links among civil societies of the Western Balkans, including through the support for the Western Balkans Fund projects.

Based on the commitments deriving from the Summit, the Fund strengthened the cooperation with European Union Commission with the purpose of supporting and promoting projects and initiatives that enhance regional cooperation, contribute to the sustainable development of the Western Balkans, and strengthen the bonds between the people of the region. It provides financial support for projects in various areas such as culture, education, scientific exchanges, sustainable development, and more.



In the years of existence, the Fund has demonstrated and proven itself as a unique cooperation mechanism and a good example to other initiatives of how to put the needs before differences in pursuit of a common, overarching goal. WBF has gone a long way and asserted itself as one of the most effective instruments encouraging cooperation in the region, including the most important element of cooperation - the people to people contact through personal relationships

H.E Ivica Dačić in 2018

SIGNING OF THE CONTRACT

After several months of preparatory work, in 12 July 2021, the Fund concluded the cooperation agreement with EU Commission by signing the contract for the WBF/EU Joint Action to foster regional cooperation and contribute to the development of the Western Balkans.

PROJECT UNIT

Upon signing the contract for the Joint Action, the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) made a significant step in the collaboration with EU Commission to implement the action by establishing the project unit.

The team is responsible for managing and overseeing the implementation of the action under the WBF/EU partnership. The project unit comprises professionals with expertise in project management, monitoring and evaluation, finance, and relevant thematic areas. This team is responsible for coordinating and executing the activities outlined in the joint action.

Moreover, the project unit manages the financial and human resources and monitors budget utilization, tracks expenditures, and ensures that resources are allocated efficiently to achieve project goals. Including the establishment of monitoring and evaluation mechanisms to assess action progress, measure results, and identify areas for improvement. WBF has created a culture of knowledge sharing where the project unit is responsible to facilitate knowledge sharing among team members, partners, and stakeholders.



The joint action of the European Union and Western Balkans Fund serves the European Union agenda in the Western Balkans and reflects our values and aspirations. We expect this cooperation to enable the grassroots organisation to engage in regional cooperation, positively impact good neighbourly relations and reconciliation, and have a greater role in the accession reforming processes. H.E Luigi Soreca, EU Delegation to Tirana at the inaugural ceremony, November 2022

***“The region is changing, and what was once impossible is becoming a reality. That shows just how much we can achieve if we opt to work together”
H.E. Olta Xhaçka, Minister of Foreign Affairs and Europe of Albania***

EU-WBF Joint Action Kick-Off Meeting

In November 23. 2021, the WBF/EU Joint Action held the Kick Off Meeting that marked the beginning of a collaborative effort between the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) and the European Union (EU) Commission to jointly support regional initiatives and projects in the Western Balkans.

This meeting brought together representatives from both organizations, diplomatic corps in Tirana, as well as relevant stakeholders, to lay the groundwork for successful cooperation and discuss the objectives, strategies, and expected outcomes of the joint action. This meeting provided great opportunity to highlight the importance of regional cooperation, the role of the

WBF and the EU in supporting the Western Balkans, and the specific goals of the joint action.

The participants had the opportunity to learn and discuss the thematic areas that will be the focus of the joint action. These areas included cultural cooperation, education and scientific exchanges, sustainable development, social inclusion, economic growth, or other relevant topics. Also, the Kick Off Meeting allowed the identification and coordination of resources and expertise from both the WBF and the EU Commission since it provided a platform for discussing how the two organizations can leverage their respective strengths and capacities to achieve common objectives

GRANT SCHEME

The scheme plays a crucial role in providing financial support to third parties for implementing projects that contribute to regional cooperation, development, and progress in the Western Balkans. Within the framework of the WBF/EU Joint Action, WBF implements grant scheme that support innovative and impactful regional projects that foster regional cooperation, contribute to sustainable development, and address key societal challenges in the Western Balkans. Through the mechanism of grant scheme, the WBF provides opportunities for civil society organizations to access funding and collaborate with regional and



Nevertheless, this meeting facilitated networking and collaboration among participants, including representatives from civil society organizations, government entities, academia, and other relevant stakeholders. It encouraged the formation of partnerships and the exchange of knowledge and best practices.

23 November 2021, the Joint Action kick-off ceremony of the EU-WBF Joint Action. First left, EU Ambassador to Tirana, H.E. Luigi Soreca. Second left, Minister of Foreign Affairs and Europe of Albania, H.E. Olta Xhaçka

ainternational partners to drive positive change in the region. By strategically investing in projects, WBF strengthens its impact in the areas linked to regional cooperation and reconciliation.

Applicants were given the opportunity to explore and propose regional initiatives that addressed one or more of the cross-cutting issues, such as gender mainstreaming, equal opportunities, the empowerment of minorities and vulnerable groups, environmental sustainability, and climate change mitigation and adaptation.

With this comprehensive approach, applicants empowered to develop impactful projects that addressed the diverse needs of the Western Balkans. The total budget allocated for the Call for Proposal was EUR 400,000, with grants available up to EUR 15,000 per project. Projects implemented under this Call had varying timelines, ranging from 3 to 10 months, allowing project teams ample time to achieve their goals and create meaningful impact in the region.

Evaluation Process

In order to ensure fairness and transparency throughout the process, the WBF/EU Joint Action implemented a rigorous evaluation criterion due to the high demand for support. Four international experts were hired and worked side by side with the WBF experts during the evaluation process.

After careful evaluation, the winners were announced in March, and their success was celebrated during the Partnership Workshop held on 14-15 April 2022 in Tirana, where winners



EU-WBF Joint Action Manager, Mr Fjordi Bisha, addressing the participants during the awarding ceremony of the 4th Call for Proposals

from the region came together. The WBF throughout implementation of its grant scheme provides its direct beneficiaries with networking opportunities, enabling them to share knowledge, experiences, and best practices with each other.

This exchange of information among grantees helps them learn from each other's successes and failures, ultimately enhancing their own projects or initiatives. Additionally, it provides a platform for grantees to identify potential collaborators who are working on similar issues or projects. By connecting with other grantees, they can explore opportunities for joint initiatives, partnerships, and resource-sharing. The implementation of regional grant schemes not only facilitates networking but also amplifies the collective impact and influence of potential applicants for the betterment of the region. By joining forces, WBF grantees can advocate for common goals, raise awareness about the region, and advocate for policy changes or systemic improvements.

Call in Numbers

1

It is the First Call for Proposals co-funded between the Western Balkans Fund and EU

4

It is the 4th Call for Proposals in the history of the WBF since establishment

12

The number of locations, two per Contracting Party, visited during the CfP

126

Stakeholders benefited from the grants, as lead-applicant or partners

207

Eligible applications were submitted during the applications timeframe

347

Total applications during the applications timeframe

800

Over Eight-Hundred new partnerships established among applicants

15.000

Euros, the maximal amount of a grant of the 4th Call for Proposals

400.000

Euros, the total amount provided to the grantees of the 4 CfP

790.889

Individuals reached through social media from Joint Action kick-off to finalisation

2.878.701

Euros, the total amount requested from the Joint-Action by applicants

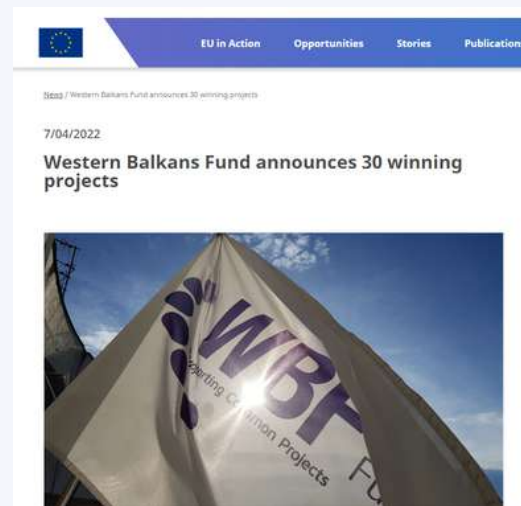
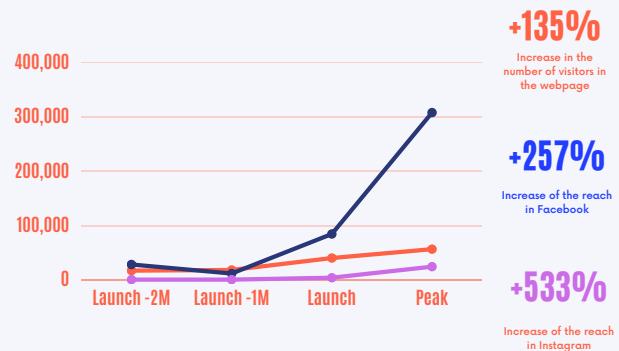
4.223.614

Euros, the total amount of funding requested from all the applicatns

Visibility & Outreach

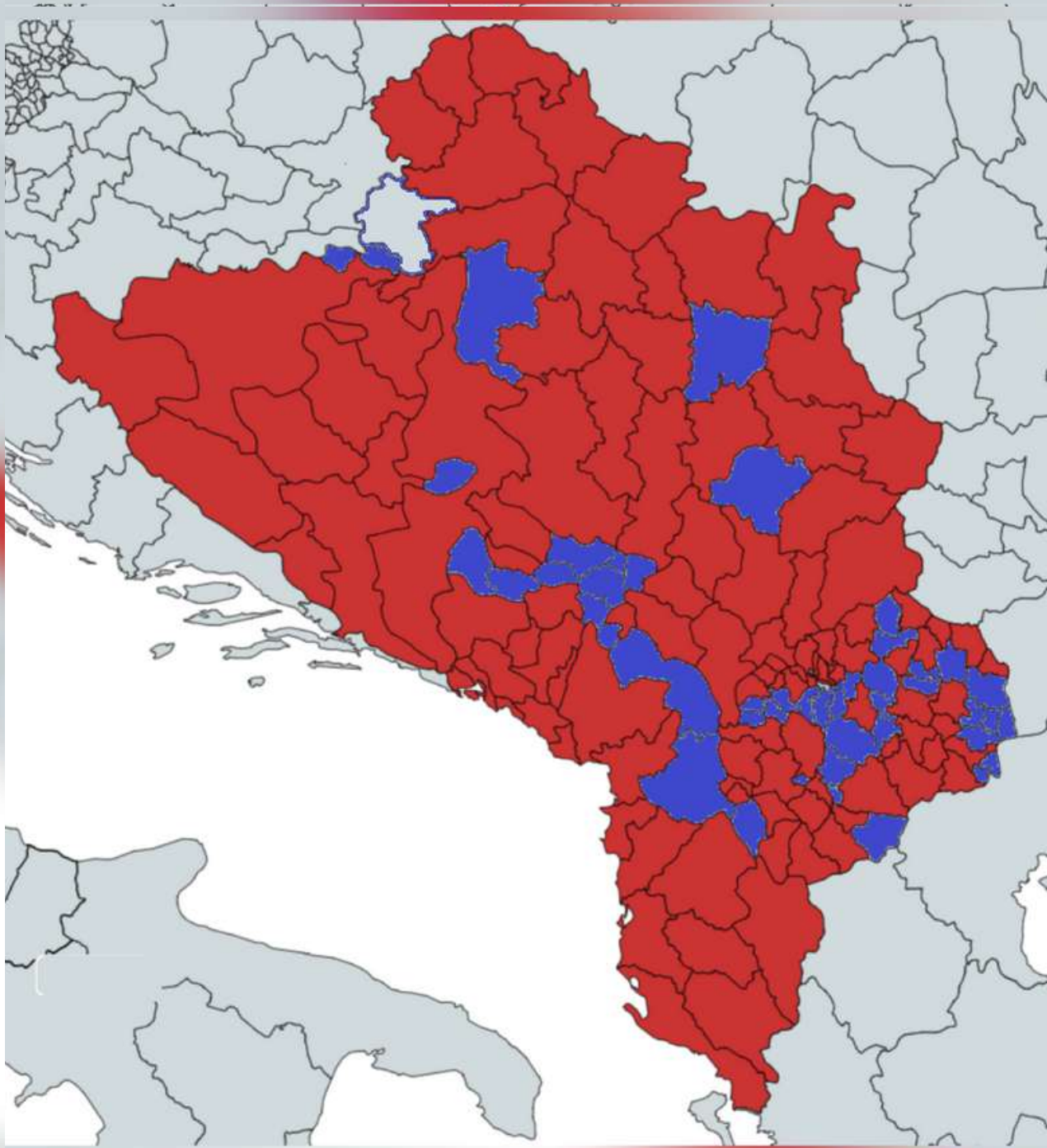
Visibility and outreach efforts have played a crucial role in disseminating information, engaging stakeholders, and promoting the activities supported by the Western Balkans Fund. WBF maintained transparency, providing guidance, and maximizing visibility, the project has effectively reached a wide audience and strengthened the impact of the initiatives supported by the Fund. The efforts of the WBF/EU Joint Action are highly successful, thanks to the support of beneficiaries, dedicated individuals, partners, and followers. Transparency and openness have been maintained throughout the project cycle, with consistent updates provided on the website and social media platforms. This has led to significant increases in the reach of information across various channels. The project has also made efforts to enhance visibility through regional televisions, radio, and newspapers, effectively transmitting the message and mission of the Western Balkans Fund to a wider audience.

This approach increased presence in media outlets has contributed to raising awareness and generating interest in the activities and initiatives supported by the Fund. A key aspect of the project is the support provided to grassroots organizations through the "Joint Action."



The specialised WeBalkans portal reports on EU-WBF joint action

The Fund has recognized the importance of monitoring and mentoring from the beginning of the project, ensuring effective implementation and reporting. Upon the award ceremony within the 4th Call for Proposals, they participated in a two-day workshop that provided them with valuable insights into the project implementation procedures, guidelines, and the Monitoring, Learning, and Evaluation component. The workshop also covered essential topics such as reporting, financial reports, and visibility, dissemination, and promotion.



85%

Applicants and participants of the 4th Call for Proposals were uniquely diverse in terms of geographical diversity. The Call successfully generated interest in more than 100 locations, covering the absolute majority of the Western Balkans territory. In red, administrative divisions from where we received applications or participation.

Regional ownership

Upon launching the Call for Proposals, the Secretariat of the Western Balkans Union embarked on a regional tour with the aim of reaching as many regional stakeholders as possible. Based on internal research regarding the potential development capabilities of grassroots civil society organizations, it was decided to visit two sites for each Contracting Party. The chosen destinations in Albania were Tirana and Korça. In Bosnia and Herzegovina, the destinations were Sarajevo and Mostar. In Kosovo*, the destinations were Prishtina/Pristina and Peja/Pec. In Montenegro, the destinations were Podgorica and Kotor. In North Macedonia, the WBF team visited Skopje and Bitola. Finally, in Serbia, Info Sessions were organized in Belgrade and Novi Sad. Representatives of the local European Delegations were invited to all the Info Sessions, and in all but one, they delivered a welcoming speech to the participants. Additionally, representatives from the media, activists, diplomats, and administration employees were invited to participate in the gatherings, which usually took place at the premises of the Ministries of Foreign Affairs of the Region, EU Centers, or private Conference Halls. All our meetings followed the protocols in place for protection against the Covid-19 Pandemic. Furthermore, due to the limited mobility imposed by the pandemic, the Western Balkans Fund



Tirana Info Session



Skopje Info Session



Belgrade Info Session



Sarajevo Info Session

provided a series of Online Info Meetings through the Zoom Platform for the first time. Over 160 people attended, choosing one of our two Info Sessions in English or the one provided in all the official languages of the Contracting Parties .



Pristina Info Session



Podgorica Info Session



Korçë Info Session



Novi Sad Info Session



Kotor Info Session



Peja Info Session

How does the Joint Action works

On 12 July 2021, the European Commission and the Western Balkans Fund signed the contract for the establishment of the Joint Action “Support to the Promotion of Civil Society Regional Actions in the Western Balkans”. Based on the contract, the EU provided an injection of 1 million Euros to support the promotion of grassroots organisations and regional cooperation for the next 30 months. In practical terms, it established a mechanism of contribution through the co-funding of the 4th and the 5th Call for Proposals launched by the WBF. Many have asked why the action is co-funded and not fully funded by the European Union? The reason is simple. The Western Balkans Fund have committed more than 400.000 Euros of its own resources to the Call for Proposals. Moreover, we have provided in kind the professional services of our Secretariat, who are paid by the Contracting Parties taxpayers. Finally, WBF also provided to the secretariat an established infrastructure, including premises and logistical capabilities. Claiming the regional ownership of the Fund, the contribution of the Western Balkans Fund towards the joint action has increased year after year. The internal funding of the WBF provides to the European Union a highly efficient operation, with over 90% EU funds supporting directly the action through grants.

Celebrating the champions



Family Picture of the 30 grantees of the 4 CfP holding their grant award certificate

WBF commenced with the implementation of the grant scheme within the framework of the WBF/EU joint action with the announcement of a Call for Proposals, that outlined the thematic areas, objectives, eligibility criteria, and application guidelines.

The Fourth Call for Proposals launched by the Western Balkans Fund (WBF)/EU Joint Action on 8 November 2021 marked a significant milestone for the organization. This call for proposals brought together the WBF and the European Union, creating a unique platform for civil society organizations to collaborate and implement regional initiatives that contribute to the development and progress of the Western Balkans.

The call was open for over a month, allowing interested applicants sufficient time to prepare and submit their Project Proposals.

The key objectives of this Call were to support initiatives that fostered regional cooperation, regional cohesion, and sustainable development. The call focused on three main areas of intervention: cultural cooperation, education and scientific exchanges, and sustainable development.

These areas were chosen to address key societal challenges and promote positive change in the region.

Monitoring & Mentoring

The monitoring and mentoring process is an important integral part of the WBF grant scheme that is mostly dedicated to the support for successful implementation of projects implemented by third parties. The monitoring process is a complex one, however the WBF assigns one Program Manager per Contracting Party who becomes the focal point for mentoring support and communication with selected grantees. Six Program Managers ensures ongoing support and guidance, that also conducted at least one in-person for monitoring purpose and provide any necessary assistance. This direct engagement allows the Fund to develop a comprehensive understanding about the projects and facilitate effective monitoring. Furthermore, with the direct support of the Monitoring, Evaluation and Learning Officer the WBF offered additional support during the reporting process, where grantees received comprehensive guidance and assistance until the completion of their projects, guaranteeing smooth project closure and accurate reporting.

WBF examined the key findings from the 4th Call for Proposals, trends and impacts of the WBF grant scheme. One notable trend was the increase in multisectoral projects, where multiple intervention areas are combined, this



WBF Senior Program Manager, Dafina Beqiri (l), mentoring the grantees of the First Joint Call for Proposal

trend demonstrates the recognition of the interconnections between different sectors and the potential for synergistic collaborations.

Specifically, there was significant interest in combining cultural cooperation with education and exchange initiatives, indicating a desire for holistic and integrated approaches. In addition, important aspect analysed was the geographic representation of lead applicants. The findings showed that in 4 out of 6 Cooperation Programs (CPs), at least two lead applicants were from non-capital cities. This distribution signifies a positive shift towards inclusivity, as it indicates that the WBF grant scheme is becoming more accessible to organizations based outside major urban centers. This decentralization of lead applicants reflects the Fund's commitment to supporting a wider range of organizations and promoting regional development across different geographical areas.



Findings

The statistical findings demonstrate the positive impact of the WBF grants on capacity building, partnership development, and knowledge sharing among grantees. The support and communication provided by the Fund have been instrumental in ensuring the success of the projects and promoting regional cooperation in the Western Balkans. While many applicants lacked prior experience with WBF grants, a majority had partners who had previous experience either as applicants or grantees. This highlights the importance of existing partnerships in successful grant applications and demonstrates the collaborative nature of the projects. The decrease in previously awarded grantees receiving new grants indicates the Fund's commitment to building new sustainable partnerships and empowering a diverse range of CSOs. Approximately half of the grantees reported utilizing monitoring support, with a significant majority stating that it was beneficial and met their needs. This highlights the effectiveness of the monitoring support provided by the WBF. Moreover, seven out of ten grantees expressed satisfaction with communication and cooperation with the WBF, indicating the positive engagement and collaboration between the Fund and project implementers.

The support provided by the WBF had a positive impact on grantees' capacity to engage in regional projects. Seven out of ten grantees reported an improvement in their ability to forge partnerships across borders, demonstrating the value of the grants in facilitating regional cooperation. Additionally, three out of four grantees had prior experience with their project partners, emphasizing the significance of established relationships. However, one out of four grantees had no previous cooperation with their selected partners, highlighting the opportunity for new collaborations. The presence of knowledge transfer between project partners was acknowledged by 90% of grantees. This transfer encompassed various aspects, including reporting, financial management, and visibility. The knowledge transfer facilitated successful cross-border and regional cooperation and contributed to the overall effectiveness of the projects

70%

Of the grantees were very satisfied with the mentoring process and believes learned important skills that will empower his/hers organisation for a long time

90%

9 out of 10 grantees has reported that some level of transfer of knowledge was present between partners (e.g. reporting, financial management, visibility or other components of cross-border / regional cooperation)

Awarded Regional Projects of the First Call for Proposals (logo of the lead-applicants)



The project promoted our region as a cultural and touristic destination, through recognizable regional cultural-tourism platform. It focused on composition of a network of artists to perform and promote in 6 cities in our region, by creating a unique regional festival platform – “Balchestra”.

“In Search of Our Musical Roots” contributed to regional cooperation, and strengthened regional cohesion in the WB6 region through creation of new jazz and contemporary music written by young composers from the WB Region and performed by an ensemble of young musicians-students.



“Media and Art in service of Reconciliation” project contributed to CSO cooperation in the WB6 region by working on reconciliation by producing new narratives among young people

Project “Contemporary Fortresses of Culture: Boka, Trebinje, Novi Sad” increased awareness of the richness of cultural heritage in our Contracting Parties, by realizing activities that encourage dialogue, and promote protection, valorisation, sustainable usage, and management.



The project contributed to the reconciliation process in Western Balkans by empowering the youth to get engaged in process of facing the past, fighting impunity for war crimes and apply critical thinking in narratives of the 90s through intercultural dialogue.

The initiation of the project “Support to women’s efforts in building regional democracy” and the establishment of a network of policy-makers is a must in order to improve the capacities and enhance support to women population in Western Balkan region.



The initiation of this joint initiative contributed to improving the livelihood of families by increasing women’s access to economic opportunities, which in turn will benefit their own families and the families of their employees.

The overall objective of the project “Regional evenings of cultural heritage” is to promote cultural cooperation and exchange among folklore ensembles in Western Balkans



The project mobilized young women with sports background to engage in ‘Leadership for women’ learning process, to build their capacity to independently organize sport-for-change activities in their local communities and to enhance mobility of young women across the Region.

The implemented project included many grassroots organisations from the Western Balkans Region, eager to participate more in regional cooperation project on social, cultural, scientific and economic topics



Working as a team in this project, participants highlighted the common prehistoric cultural heritage and through various actions promoted the ancient culture among local communities, national representatives, young people and prominent specialists of humanities.

Following the overall objective of the Call, project aimed to strengthen the collaboration and promote the unique identity of WB region through a broad range of activities related to sustainable form of tourism.



Art for Reconciliation is the project idea introduced by TULLA Cultural Centre and Urban Development Centre and PriFilmFest that introduced new views on cooperation and reconciliation through arts

The project included a set of activities with the overall objective of contributing to the meaningful participation of youth, in promoting intercultural dialogue as means of building good neighbourly relations, reconciliation and peace through a collaborative approach and joint activities.



This project united talented peoples with disabilities and empowered them through training on artisanal work and by providing a direct link to the market



By providing knowledge and support to young filmmakers to develop, produce and disseminate their collaborative works, the project steered public debate towards gender equality, climate change, reconciliation and human rights.

"Mainstreaming Humanity in Western Balkans: From Education to Reconciliation" fostered intra-regional mobility and youth networking, as well as a more proactive approach of young generations towards topics of concern in their domestic contexts



The project strengthened the capacities of NGO partners related to the protection and monitoring of bird species through research camps

GERMIN introduced the idea of a fellowship that aimed to meet the demand for pragmatic and thoughtful responses to the challenges and opportunities that large-scale migration in Western Balkan Region presents to communities and institutions in a globalized world.



The project aimed to enhance cooperation in the field of environment and climate change and to collect and share experiences and best practices on environmental activism in the Western Balkan region.

The project aimed to enhance regional cooperation among history educators and to advance sustainable mutual understanding through the development and promotion of a common approach to teaching



Through this unique project, we established children's experiences of participation in their homes, schools, and communities including the importance of the relational context, not only in formal structures and support their participation based on notions of competence and voice

The Impact Centre fellowship enhanced regional cooperation in education field, contributing directly to increased cooperation and Reconciliation process



This project promoted cycling in the WB and attempts successfully the establishment of greenways, with the purpose of creating a common cycling network

Partnership for mothers and babies project supports both mothers and babies through creating a comfortable space in public for breastfeeding, bottlefeeding and changing – whenever the babies need it



"The Game Jam" action was developed through empowerment of game developers to further enhance their skills in game development with a focus on training female leaders in order to ensure an easier transition to the job market

This project contributed to the regional cooperation, and strengthened regional cohesion in the WB6 region since it brought together pillars of the society that continue struggling with lack of conditions to conduct their entrepreneurial performance.



Cross Border Co-working Cooperation (CBCC) project contributed to regional and cross-border cooperation through an innovative approach to sustainable tourism growth and economic development.

"Leap to Success" was a 4-month regional project where three organizations from three different Contracting Parties joined their forces in order to contribute to the regional development and provide better future for the youth in the respective CP's.



FLAG project brought together regional CSO to participate and cooperate together over major sustainability issues that confront their communities.

1. ART FOR RECONCILIATION



Art for Reconciliation a project that brought together three partners led by TULLA Cultural Centre from Albania, Urban Development Centre from Serbia, and PriFilmFest from Kosovo.

The joint initiative aimed to bring forth new perspectives on cooperation and reconciliation through the medium of arts. The collaborative nature of Art for Reconciliation fostered a sense of unity and collective ownership among the participating artists.

This approach contributed to the development of trust and mutual respect, essential elements for fostering regional cooperation. The idea itself was conceptualized during a period marked by the clear consequences of a global crisis that had fundamentally changed our realities and norms.

At that time, art played a crucial role in managing the stress caused by the COVID-19 pandemic. However, the pandemic also redefined the vision and approach to art, leaving it somewhat neglected. It challenged divisive narratives and promoted a shared sense of responsibility and ownership over the region's future, ultimately working towards a more united and cooperative Western Balkans.

A project led by Tulla Culture Center in Tirana.

With partners, Centar za Urban Razvoj in Belgrade and PriFilm Festival in Prishtina

Activities took place in Tirana, Belgrade and Prishtina



2. BALCHESTRA



A project led by Artlink Association, based in Belgrade.

With partners, Artplus in Tirana, Association for Affirmation of Musical Culture in Skopje and International Peace Center in Sarajevo.

Activities took place in Belgrade, Prizren, Tirane, Skopje, Kotor and Sarajevo.

The regional orchestra of Artink, composed of 35 young musicians from across the Western Balkans region, has played a significant role in fostering regional cooperation, cultural exchange, and understanding.

Through their performances of classical masterpieces, the orchestra has not only captivated art enthusiasts but also contributed to the promotion of tourism and the shared cultural heritage of the participating locations. With the selection of renowned classical compositions and showcasing them in various cities such as Belgrade, Prizren, Tirana, Kotor, Sarajevo, and Skopje, the regional orchestra of Artink has created a platform for cultural appreciation and engagement.

The orchestra's presence and performances in each of the Contracting Parties have contributed to the visibility and recognition of the cultural richness of the Western Balkans.

This experience highlighted the musical traditions and achievements of the participating parties.

Furthermore, the regional orchestra of Artink has served as a catalyst for cultural exchange among the diverse communities of the Western Balkans. Project successfully brought together musicians from different Contracting Parties and backgrounds, the project has created opportunities for collaboration, learning, and the sharing of musical knowledge and techniques.

3. BALKAN SHORTS FILM NETWORK



The project's objective to promote intercultural dialogue at a local level in Struga, Ulcinj, and Bajina Basta has recognized the challenges that smaller communities often face, including closed attitudes and intolerance towards sensitive topics.

In order to address these issues, the project focused on empowering young filmmakers by providing them with knowledge, support, and resources to develop, produce, and share their collaborative works.

The selected key topics, such as gender equality, climate change, reconciliation, human rights, and democratic values, reflect the pressing issues faced by these communities.

The project's design took advantage of the extensive and diverse experience of the consortium members, ensuring a comprehensive and well-rounded approach. The involvement of local filmmakers and drawing upon their unique perspectives, the project was able to address the specific challenges and context of each community. Through the empowerment of young filmmakers and the amplification of their voices, the project aimed to challenge preconceived notions, break down barriers, and foster greater understanding and acceptance.



**A project led by UG
Akademska Scena in
Bajina Basta.**

**With partners,
Association for cultural
affirmation Bager Genesis
2.0 in Struga and NVO Ja
Djelujem in Ulcinj.**

**Activities took place in Bajina Basta,
Struga and Ulcinj.**

4. BIRDS WITHOUT BORDERS



**A project led by “CZIP”,
based in Podgorica.**

**With partners, Bird
Protection and
Research Society of
Serbia and Albanian
Ornithological Society.**

**Activities took place in
Ulcinj, Saranda and
Kikinda.**



The partnership of this regional initiative recognized the critical importance of biodiversity for sustaining life on Earth, including human life. By encompassing a wide range of animals, plants, and microorganisms, biodiversity supports healthy ecosystems that provide us with essential resources such as clean air and food. With this understanding, the project aimed to raise awareness about the dangers of biodiversity loss while promoting tourism as a means to engage and educate the public.

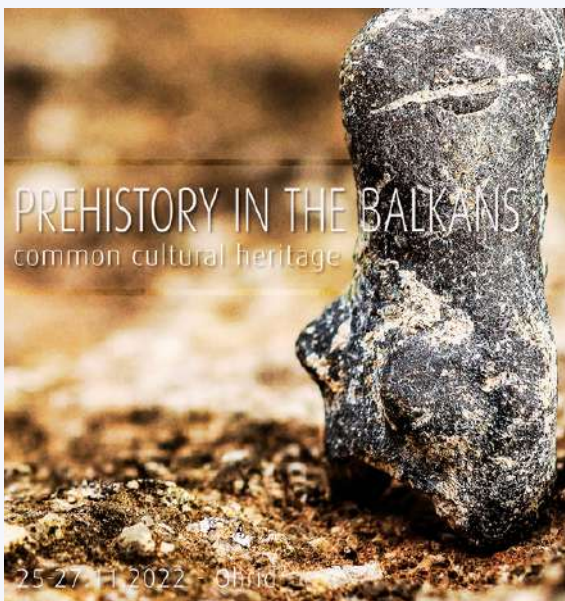
Objectives of this regional initiative were carefully formulated to maximize efficiency and efficacy. Firstly, it aimed to foster collaboration among non-governmental organizations, recognizing the importance of collective efforts in addressing biodiversity challenges.

Bringing together different organizations, the project sought to leverage their expertise and resources to achieve a greater impact.

Secondly, the project focused on advancing knowledge regarding migratory bird species in the Western Balkan region. Migratory birds play a crucial role in ecosystems and their conservation requires a deep understanding of their behavior, habitats, and migration patterns.

Thirdly, the project emphasized empowering young individuals through active engagement in environmental conservation efforts.

5. COMMON CULTURAL HERITAGE: INTERREGIONAL RESEARCH AND EDUCATIONAL PRACTICES



The regional initiative "Common Cultural Heritage: Interregional research and educational practices" sought to uncover and promote the shared prehistoric cultural heritage among the participating CPs.

By emphasizing the contributions of women experts and involving students, the project aimed to create a sense of shared identity, mutual understanding, and ownership within the communities.

The regional initiative brought together experts and students from three distinguished Contracting Parties (CPs): the Institute of Archaeology, Academy for Albanian Studies and the Faculty of Philosophy - Belgrade. The project had a twofold objective.

Focusing on the prehistoric era, the project aimed to uncover and promote the shared historical roots and cultural connections among the involved regions. Secondly, aimed to promote these principles of common cultural heritage among a diverse range of target groups.

One important aspect of the project was to acknowledge and elevate the contributions of women experts specializing in prehistory. This recognition aimed to challenge gender stereotypes and promote inclusivity within the field. Another crucial target group of the project was comprised of students from the participating CPs, creating a sense of ownership and pride within the communities.



A project led by Center for Prehistoric Research in Skopje.

With partners, Institute of Archaeology, Academy for Albanian Studies in Tirana and Faculty of Philosophy in Belgrade.

Activities took place in Bregalnica (Vlaho site Pelagonia), Vinca, Piva and Pogradec .

6. CREATING A CROSS-BORDER NETWORK FOR SOCIO-ECONOMIC SUSTAINABILITY

A project led by FLAG Association in Tirana.

With partners, Agency for Management of Protected Areas of Podgorica and Environment and Youth Capacity Development, EYCD in Prishtina.



Activities took place in Podgorica, Prishtina, Tirana and Shkoder.



This regional initiative aimed to address the fragmentation of sustainable development efforts in the Western Balkans by promoting knowledge sharing, collaboration, and volunteerism. With empowerment of communities and facilitating closer ties between stakeholders, the project aimed to build resilience, enhance emergency response capabilities, and contribute to the overall sustainability and well-being of the region.

The project emerged from the recognition that while central government agencies and some local governments have received training in sustainable development, many civil society organizations (CSOs) still lack the knowledge and experience in certain areas covered by the project's call. It addressed this gap by promoting

knowledge sharing and collaboration among diverse stakeholders. By bringing together NGOs, local governments, and other relevant actors, the project sought to bridge the knowledge and experience divide.

The sharing of diverse experiences and best practices would empower communities to take action, both individually and collectively, towards sustainable development goals. The project also took into account the impact of extreme weather events witnessed in Europe in recent years.

By establishing a network and engaging in discussions with local authorities, the project, led by FLAG, established a database of organizations involved in approaches addressing sustainability challenges and emergency response.

7. CONTEMPORARY FORTRESSES OF CULTURE

A project led by Don Branko Sbutega Foundation, based in Kotor. With partners, Društvo građana Podbare "Almašani" in Novi Sad and Udruženje građana "Mostovi" Trebinje.

Activities took place in Kotor, Trebinje and Novi Sad.



The regional initiative titled "Contemporary Fortresses of Culture: Boka, Trebinje, Novi Sad" successfully raised awareness about the richness and significance of cultural heritage within the Contracting Parties involved.

Through a carefully planned series of activities, the project aimed to foster dialogue, protect cultural assets, promote sustainable usage practices, and embrace integrated approaches to both tangible and intangible cultural heritage. The project recognized the immense potential of cultural heritage in contributing to sustainable development and regional cooperation.

It sought to revive forgotten narratives and architectural marvels from the Austro-Hungarian era, while also celebrating intangible aspects such as traditions, customs, and artistic expressions.

These initiatives aimed to raise awareness, promote understanding, and encourage active participation in the preservation and valorisation of cultural heritage. Nurturing regional cooperation and collaboration, the project created a shared understanding and appreciation of the diverse cultural heritage within the CPs.

8. CROSS-BORDER CO-WORKING COOPERATION

A project led by Intera Technological Park in Mostar.

With partners, Proaktiv Organisation based in Nis and Innovation and Entrepreneurship Center Tehnopolis based in Niksic. Activities took place in Mostar, Jahorina, Niksic and Nis.



The regional initiative titled: Cross Border Coworking Conference aimed to promote the coworking concept and position the Western Balkans region as an attractive destination for digital nomads.

The conference as milestone activity of the project brought together over 100 participants from over 10 different nationalities, who gathered to assess the current situation in the region and engage in discussions on ways to enhance its appeal for digital nomads. During the conference, Biljana Šćepanović, the Minister of Science and Technological Development of Montenegro, highlighted the progress made in Montenegro regarding legal regulations, programs, and strategic initiatives aimed at

attracting digital nomads and creating favourable conditions for their arrival and stay.

Throughout the project it was demonstrated the commitment of the region as a whole to embrace the opportunities presented by the digital nomad lifestyle.

These concepts are relatively new but hold immense potential for the region in terms of strengthening investment opportunities, establishing robust market linkages, facilitating networking opportunities, and fostering business partnerships within the Western Balkans.

9. ENHANCING REGIONAL COOPERATION OF YOUNG RESEARCHERS ON MIGRATION

The Western Balkans region holds significant relevance in the study of migration due to its various forms, such as labour migration, high-skilled migration, forced migration, diaspora formation, and return migration.

However, despite the importance of this region, it has received relatively limited attention from migration scholars and researchers. Recognizing this gap, the idea of a fellowship program was conceived to address the demand for practical and thoughtful responses to the challenges and opportunities presented by large-scale migration in Western Balkan Contracting Parties.

Through the fellowship program, scholars and practitioners could work together to understand the complexities of migration dynamics, identify best practices, and propose innovative solutions. One of the key objectives of the fellowship program was to foster dialogue and collaboration among stakeholders, including researchers, policymakers, and practitioners.

Moreover, the fellowship program recognized the globalized nature of communities and institutions and aimed to foster international cooperation and networking. By connecting scholars and experts from the Western Balkans with their counterparts from other regions, the program sought to facilitate the exchange of ideas, experiences, and best practices.



A project led by GERMIN, in Prishtina

With partners, Center for Support of Local and Regional Development CeP in Herceg Novi and Association Estima in Bitola.

Activities took place in Prishtina, Podgorica, Herceg Novi, Bitola and Skopje.

10. FEMALE LEADERSHIP CAMP



A project led by Fun Schools Association based in Sarajevo.

With partners, FK Breznica in Pljevlja and Open Schools in Belgrade. Activities took place in Pljevlja



The Female Leadership Camp, led by the lead-applicant Udruženje Otvorene škole fudbala in Sarajevo, in collaboration with ZFK Breznica and Sportsko udruženje Otvorene škole fudbala as partners, brought together 30 young women from diverse ethnic backgrounds representing three different Contracting Parties.

The camp aimed to empower these young women by equipping them with essential leadership skills, fostering their understanding of civic engagement, and emphasizing the value of voluntary actions.

Throughout the camp, the participants had the opportunity to meet, interact, and engage in open dialogue and cooperation.

The program was carefully designed to provide a platform for the young women to learn and develop leadership qualities that would enable them to make positive contributions to their communities.

The camp exposed them to a range of training activities, workshops, and discussions aimed at enhancing their leadership capabilities and expanding their understanding of civic responsibilities. The primary focus of the camp was to equip the young women with essential leadership skills. They were provided with training in areas such as communication, decision-making, problem-solving, teamwork, and project management.

The participants had the opportunity to learn from one another's experiences, share perspectives, and build connections across ethnic boundaries.

11. GAME JAM



A project led by IPKO Foundation in Prishtina.

With partners, Cyber Security, Corporate Security and Crisis Management Initiative - C3I in Skopje and WIT Center in Tirana. Activities took place in Prishtina.

This initiative expanded from local to regional one, by IPKO Foundation's is a pioneering effort to harness the potential of the computer gaming industry and empower young individuals in the Western Balkans region. By providing them with the necessary skills and knowledge, the initiative aimed to open doors to new career opportunities, foster entrepreneurship, and tap into the economic potential of this rapidly growing industry.

This regional initiative aimed to empower young individuals from across the Western Balkans region by providing them with the opportunity to learn the process of developing computer games.

This industry has a significant market value, surpassing the size of Hollywood by several folds, with a market value of \$195 billion. The Game Jam event aimed to tap into the potential of the computer gaming industry, which offers numerous opportunities for creative expression, entrepreneurship, and economic growth.

By providing young individuals with the skills and knowledge required to develop video games, the initiative sought to enable them to participate in this thriving industry. These groups collaborated, brainstormed, and applied their newly acquired skills to create their own unique games.

12. HELLO NEIGHBOOR

This heartfelt project, initiated by three women who share a common vision, aimed to promote the Western Balkans as a unified region. Their trust, passion, energy, and commitment were evident in every aspect of the project, with the goal of inspiring participants to see, work, travel, and love the Balkans as one cohesive entity.

The project team, partners, and interns collectively dedicated 180 days to promoting mobility within the region, specifically focusing on internships within civil society organizations.

One of the key achievements of the project was the successful implementation of the idea to rotate interns among the three participating Contracting Parties. This approach provided valuable cross-cultural experiences and fostered collaboration among interns from different backgrounds.

The 12 interns who participated in the project became ambassadors for regional exchange in internships, further promoting the concept of unity in the Western Balkans. Additionally, the project impacted the lives of 310 individuals directly involved in various roles, who, like the project team, became enthusiastic advocates for the region.

A project led by Impact Centre in Tirana.

With partners, Media Promo Info in Casin and Youth Initiative for Human Rights in Montenegro.

Activities took place in Korca, Vlora, Skrapar, Lushnja, Lezha, Tirana, Podgorica, Niksic, Budva, Rozaje, Tuzla, Sarajevo, Cazin, and Zenica.



13. I LOVE BALKAN



A project led by NGO Lady, based in Prishtina. With partners, Observatory for Children and Youth Human Rights in Tirana; Poduzetnice In in Sarajevo; Association of Women Entrepreneurs of Montenegro in Podgorica; Macedonian Women's Rights Centre - Shelter Centre Skopje; Association of Women Filigran Art in Kragujevac and Balkan Women Association in Prishtina. Activities took place in Prishtina

This joint regional initiative titled: I love Balkans, demonstrated a commitment to empowering women, promoting gender equality, and fostering economic growth, by focusing on women entrepreneurs and addressing the specific challenges they faced, the project made strides toward creating a more inclusive and supportive business environment.

This joint initiative had a significant impact on improving livelihoods for families by enhancing women's access to economic opportunities. Recognizing the importance of inclusivity and equal opportunities, the project specifically supported women entrepreneurs who had been affected by conflict as well as those with disabilities.

By doing so, it not only empowered the women themselves but also had a positive ripple effect on their families and the families of their employees. The project culminated in a notable conference, where female leaders from all the Contracting Parties participated and delivered keynote speeches.

Moreover, by combining the promotion of gender equality with enterprise development, the project acknowledged the immense potential of women entrepreneurs and aimed to create an enabling environment that maximized their contributions to local economies. It recognized the barriers that hindered their progress and sought to dismantle them.

14. In search of our Musical Roots



A project led by Jazz Art Association, based in Podgorica.

With partners, Academy of Music at Golce Delcev University of Stip, Syri Blue Association in Tirana, Academy of Arts of the University of Banja Luka and University of Arts in Belgrade. Activities took place in Podgorica, Tirana and Banja Luka.

"In Search of Our Musical Roots" successfully promoted regional cooperation and artistic exchange within the Western Balkans, by empowering young musicians and composers to explore their cultural heritage and create new compositions. The project contributed to the preservation and evolution of the region's musical traditions. It not only fostered a sense of shared identity and collaboration but also provided a platform for the participants to thrive professionally, making a lasting impact on the regional music scene.

The project titled "In Search of Our Musical Roots" aimed to expand and nurture collaborative musical creativity among young musicians from the WB Region. Following the path of a previous WBF-supported project, it focused on creating new jazz and contemporary music compositions, which were crafted by talented young composers from the region. These compositions were then performed by a talented ensemble of young student musicians.

By providing a platform for these young artists to collaborate and showcase their skills, the project played a crucial role in supporting their artistic development and promoting inter-regional collaboration. This approach fostered a deeper understanding of their cultural heritage while encouraging exploration of innovative musical avenues.

15. INTERCULTURAL DIALOGUE FOR JOINT PAST NARRATIVE AND RECONCILIATION

A project led by Youth Initiative for Human Rights Montenegro, based in Podgorica. With partners, Youth Initiative for Human Rights in Bosnia and Hercegovina in Sarajevo and Youth Initiative for Human Rights in Serbia, based in Belgrade. Activities took place in Podgorica, Sarajevo and Belgrade.



This joint regional initiative aimed to contribute to the reconciliation process in the Western Balkans by empowering youth through intercultural dialogue for a joint past narrative and reconciliation. The project actively encouraged youth engagement in confronting the past, particularly the narratives surrounding the conflicts of the 1990s in the Western Balkans.

Another important aspect of the project was to address the issue of impunity for war crimes committed during the conflicts. Through raising awareness and advocating for justice, the project aimed to combat impunity and contribute to the reconciliation process.

This initiative provided a very safe platform that encouraged youth to think critically about the narratives of the 90s, the project sought to challenge stereotypes, prejudices, and divisive narratives.

This approach fostered a more nuanced understanding of the past and promote reconciliation. The added value of this initiative focuses on the field of transnational justice, which involves addressing war crimes and human rights violations across borders. With the engagement of youth, the project addressed cross-border cooperation and contribute to the reconciliation process.

16. INTERCULTURAL DIALOGUE: A TOOL FOR YOUTH TO YOUTH CONNECTION



This regional initiative aimed to empower youth with the knowledge, skills, and platforms necessary to promote intercultural dialogue, reconciliation, and peace in their communities. The project implementation approach emphasized the need to build capacities, promoting a culture of peace in schools, and fostering collaboration through an online platform, the project sought to create a lasting impact on the participating youth and contribute to a more peaceful and inclusive society.

A core group consisting of 15 students and 3 teachers from targeted schools was formed. They received training in intercultural dialogue and peacebuilding during a two-day joint workshop. The goal was to equip them with the necessary knowledge and skills to become advocates for peace and diversity in their schools and communities.



A project led by
Albanian Foundation
for Conflict Resolution
and Reconciliation of
Disputes in Tirana.

With partners,
Association Interactive
Education and
Resource Network -
IMOR in Bitola and
Nansen Dialogue
Centre Mostar

Activities took place in
Durrës, Bitola and Mostar .

Workshops and sessions were organized in the targeted high schools, involving 300 students and 15 teachers. These interactive sessions aimed to promote a culture of peace, tolerance, and respect for diversity.

The participants worked together to develop promotional materials such as leaflets, posters, paintings, drawings, and essays. These materials served as visual representations of their commitment to peace and were displayed within the schools.

17. LEAP TO SUCCESS



The joint regional initiative titled: Leap to Success had a clear focus on fostering intercultural dialogue, reconciliation, and peace among youth in Albania, North Macedonia, and Bosnia and Herzegovina. It aimed to achieve its objectives through three main strategies.

The project strengthened the capacities of a core group consisting of 15 students and 3 teachers from targeted schools. The project sought to promote a culture of peace and respect for diversity in high schools through workshops and the creation of promotional materials. Workshops and sessions were organized in the targeted high schools, involving 300 students and 15 teachers.

These sessions aimed to raise awareness and facilitate discussions on topics related to intercultural dialogue, human rights, tolerance, and peaceful conflict resolution. Additionally, the students were engaged in creating promotional materials such as leaflets, posters, paintings, drawings, and essays, which served as tangible representations of their understanding and commitment to peace.

Lastly, the project aimed to foster collaboration among students through an online platform. An online platform on social media was created to facilitate the exchange of ideas and opinions among approximately 450 students. This platform served as a space for discussion and dialogue on topics related to human rights, tolerance, and peaceful conflict resolution.



A project led by AGORA Organisation in Skopje.

With partners, Metropolitan Incubator in Tirana and Deli Space for Creative Activity in Nis.

Activities took place in Ohrid.

18. MAINSTREAMING HUMANITY IN THE WESTERN BALKANS



A project led by Faculty of Political Sciences, University of Belgrade.

With partners, Humanistic Studies of the University of Donja Gorica in Podgorica; Belgrade International Law Circle and Faculty of Political Sciences University of Sarajevo

Activities took place in Belgrade .

The joint regional initiative had a clear focus on fostering intercultural dialogue, reconciliation, and peace among youth in Albania, North Macedonia, and Bosnia and Herzegovina. It aimed to achieve its objectives through three main strategies. Initially, the project aimed to build the capacities of a core group consisting of 15 students and 3 teachers from targeted schools.

This group received training in intercultural dialogue and peacebuilding during a two-day joint workshop. Within the framework of the project students were equipped with the necessary skills and knowledge to act as catalysts for positive change within their respective communities.

Moreover, the project sought to promote a culture of peace and respect for diversity in high schools through workshops and the creation of promotional materials. Workshops and sessions were organized in the targeted high schools, involving 300 students and 15 teachers, where through these sessions the project raised awareness and facilitate discussions on topics related to intercultural dialogue, human rights, tolerance, and peaceful conflict resolution.

Additionally, the students were engaged in creating promotional materials such as leaflets, posters, paintings, drawings, and essays, which served as tangible representations of their understanding and commitment to peace.

19. MEDIA AND ART IN SERVICE OF THE RECONCILIATION



The joint regional initiative titled "Media and Art in Service of Reconciliation" recognized the importance of media literacy in fostering understanding, combating stereotypes, prejudices, and xenophobia among young people. The project focused on young adults aged 18–26 from the participating Contracting Parties, aiming to empower them with critical media analysis skills and promote reconciliation in the Western Balkans.

Through a careful selection process, a group of young participants was chosen to analyse various media portals reporting on the same event, the Srebrenica Massacre. The project engaged 300 beneficiaries who collectively conducted a media analysis, identifying common threats and instances of disinformation.

The critical approach towards the examination of media coverage, the participants developed a deeper understanding of how narratives can shape public perceptions and contribute to the perpetuation of divisions. In addition to media analysis, the project encouraged artistic expression as a means of promoting reconciliation. Songwriters among the participants created songs dedicated to the victims of the tragic events of the 1990s, utilizing music as a powerful medium to convey emotions, empathy, and messages of unity.

Throughout the project, a change in attitude was observed among the participants. A significant majority of them declared themselves ready to engage and explore the Western Balkans region, indicating a shift towards a more open and inclusive mindset.

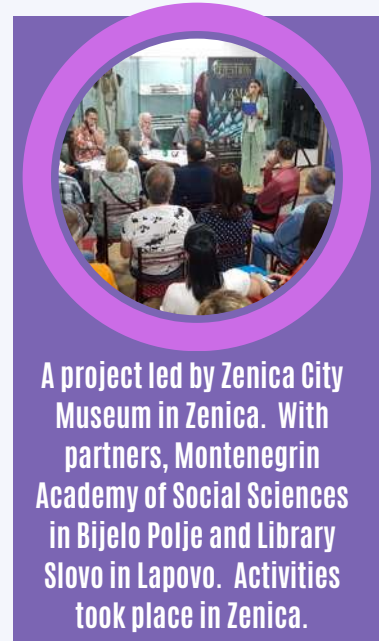
**A project led by
"Kulturanova",
based in
Petrovaradin, Novi
Sad.**

**With partners, "Our
Children"
Association in Zenica
and Art and
Community Center
Artpolis in Prishtina.**



**Activities took place in
Srebrenica, Zenica and
Novi Sad**

20. MESSAGES FROM THE PAST



A project led by Zenica City Museum in Zenica. With partners, Montenegrin Academy of Social Sciences in Bijelo Polje and Library Slovo in Lapovo. Activities took place in Zenica.

The project "Messages from the Past" had a clear objective of contributing to the reconciliation process in the Western Balkans by empowering the youth and encouraging their active engagement in confronting the past. The project aimed to combat impunity for war crimes, promote critical thinking, and foster intercultural dialogue across diverse ethnic, religious, and national backgrounds in the region.

The project's focus was intercultural dialogue and it sought to create an environment of cooperation and understanding among young people, despite the historical divisions and conflicts that have affected the region. Through cross-border collaboration and discussions on sensitive topics related to the narratives of the 1990s, the project aimed to challenge stereotypes, prejudices, and divisions that perpetuate conflict. The project recognized the importance of youth participation in the

reconciliation process and aimed to enhance their knowledge, awareness, and preparedness to engage in intercultural cooperation on highly sensitive topics.

Throughout activities, the project equipped young people with the necessary skills, information, and platforms for dialogue, the project fostered an environment where the youth could critically analyse the past, confront divisive narratives, and work towards reconciliation.

Intercultural dialogue played a central role in the project, providing a space for young people to share their perspectives, challenge assumptions, and foster understanding. The project directly influenced the reconciliation process by addressing the most divisive issues within the society.

21. PARTNERSHIP FOR MOTHER AND BABIES



The joint regional initiative titled "Partnership for Mother and Babies" recognized the importance of creating a comfortable and supportive environment for mothers and babies in public spaces.

Within the project framework it was envisioned to install these benches with changing tables, aiming to make it easier for mothers to attend to their babies' needs while in public spaces. This initiative directly contributed to enhancing the well-being of both mothers and infants by providing them with a convenient and accessible space for caregiving. A key message of the project was the normalization of breastfeeding in public spaces.

With the promotion and normalization of breastfeeding in public, the project encourages more mothers to breastfeed confidently and comfortably, thus supporting the health and well-being of both mothers and babies.

Furthermore, the project recognizes the broader impact of creating family-friendly and accommodating cities in the region and the Western Balkans. This approach raised awareness for the need to improve the living conditions for families and providing nurturing environments, whereas the project fostered a sense of community and support. It acknowledged the value of inclusive and supportive spaces for families, ultimately enhancing the quality of life for parents and children.



A project led by
"Gradjanski Glas
Montenegro", based
in Budva.

With partners,
Fondacija Zenski
Centar in Trebinje and
Women to Women
Association in
Shkodra.

Activities took place
in Bar, Shkodër and
Trebinje.

22. PROMOTING THE WESTERN BALKANS GREENWAYS



A project led by YUGO Cycling, based in Belgrade. With partners, NU Nature Lovers in Niksic and the Mountain Biking Association in Mostar. Activities took place in Priboj, Uvac, Herceg Novi and Trebinje.

The project "Promoting the Western Balkans Greenways" aimed to capitalize on the growing trend of greenways in Europe and expand the network in the Western Balkans region. Greenways provide sustainable pathways for non-motorized vehicles, offering environmentally friendly transportation options in both urban and rural areas.

The Western Balkans region has a unique opportunity to utilize disused narrow-gauge railways, remnants of historical clashes between the Austrian-Hungarian and Ottoman Empires, as potential greenway routes. These railway lines can be transformed into greenways, providing scenic and accessible paths for cyclists, walkers, and other non-motorized users.

The project facilitated interventions in selected locations, and demonstrated the feasibility and benefits of greenways, paving the way for further development. Through their work, the project provided a clear understanding of the current situation and identify obstacles for the development of greenways in the Western Balkans.

The findings and insights gathered are shared with multiple stakeholders, including local communities, government agencies, and other interested parties, to facilitate the rapid multiplication of greenway lines across the region. With the promotion of the expansion of greenways, the project contributes to sustainable and eco-friendly transportation options in the Western Balkans.

23. PROTECTION OF NATURAL AND CULTURAL HERITAGE



A project led by Stena Stenae, based in Demir Kapija.

With partners, Municipality of Demir Kapija, Department of Geography and tourism of the Novi Sad University; Birds of Albania in Tirana and Park Piva in Pluzine.

Activities took place in Demir Kapija, Park Piva and Valamara protected area near Pogradec.



This regional initiative aimed to promote sustainable tourism in the Western Balkan region by conserving and showcasing its natural and cultural heritage. The region possesses a rich and diverse array of attractions, yet they are not fully recognized or promoted to their potential visitors.

By valuing and conserving these assets, the project seeks to establish a foundation for sustainable tourism that aligns with conservation and awareness-raising goals. The project-initiated collaboration between the Demir Kapija, Piva, and Valamara protected areas in the region.

This collaboration resulted in tangible benefits through the sharing of best practices and experiences. The project managed to leverage the potential of geoparks and nature-based destinations, the project aims to develop more sustainable tourism practices that align with COP 26 and the UN Sustainable Development Goals. The use of a GIS (Geographic Information System) database will facilitate predictions, calculations, and mitigation actions in various sectors, aiding in the planning and management of sustainable tourism initiatives.

24. REGIONAL EVENINGS OF CULTURAL HERITAGE



The project "Regional Evenings of Cultural Heritage" aims to promote cultural cooperation and exchange among folklore ensembles in the Western Balkans. Folklore ensembles, as custodians of tradition and national culture, have an important role in preserving and promoting cultural heritage.

The project recognizes the potential of folklore ensembles to go beyond national boundaries and act as ambassadors of cultural diversity and shared heritage. With the idea of bringing people together ensembles from different contracting parties within the Western Balkans region, the project fosters mutual understanding, reconciliation, and good neighbourly relations.

Through collaborative performances, workshops, and cultural events, the project created opportunities for meaningful interactions and exchanges among the participating ensembles.

Cultural heritage to a wider audience. The performances in Banja Luka, Belgrade, and Ohrid attracted a large number of admirers, providing them with the opportunity to experience the richness and diversity of the region's cultural heritage.

Furthermore, the project serves as a platform to raise awareness about the work of the Western Balkans Fund and its dedication to reconciliation and large-scale regional cooperation.

A project led by the Ensemble of folk dances and songs "Veselin Maslesa" in Banja Luka.

With partners, Academic Cultural Artistic Association "SPANAC" in Belgrade and The Folklore Ensemble of dance and song "Skopje" - Skopje

Activities took place in Banja Luka, Beograd and Ohrid.

25. REGIONAL INVESTMENT PROMOTION



A project led by Chamber of Trade and Industry of Kosovo, with centre in Prishtina.

With partners, Economic Chamber of Northwest Macedonia in Skopje and Chamber of Economy of Montenegro in Podgorica

Activities took place in Prishtina, Podgorica and Skopje.

The project "Regional Investment Promotion" aimed to address the challenges faced by the entrepreneurship sector in the Western Balkans region and strengthen regional cooperation and cohesion. One of the key challenges was the decline in buying power, which affected the growth of businesses in the region.

Additionally, the labour force was seeking opportunities outside the WB6, leading to a drain of talent. To overcome these challenges, the project focused on enhancing regional investment potentials and fostering economic collaboration within the Western Balkans. It aimed to establish strong market linkages, facilitate networking opportunities, and foster business partnerships. The promotion of regional investment attracts investors and encourages the growth of businesses in the region, ultimately contributing to economic development and job creation. The project also emphasized the exchange of knowledge and experiences among chambers of commerce and businesses operating in the region.



A project led by Kosovo Institute of Media and Communication.

With partners, Gradjanski Glas in Budva and Mediator Room in Belgrade.

Activities took place in Prishtina.

26. SUPPORT TO WOMEN'S EFFORT IN BUILDING REGIONAL DEMOCRACY



The regional initiative titled "Support to Women's Efforts in Building Regional Democracy" aimed to empower women and promote gender equality in the Western Balkans by focusing on the role of media and fostering constructive dialogue among leaders and policymakers. Recognizing the importance of media in shaping public opinion and influencing societal attitudes, the project sought to harness the power of media to promote gender equality and women's empowerment.

It acknowledged the potential challenges posed by financial resources linked to political interests, which could impact editorial decisions and hinder progress in the gender equality movement. Through convening leaders and policymakers from the region, the project created a platform for dialogue and collaboration.

These discussions allowed for the exchange of insights, experiences, and best practices in promoting gender equality. The project facilitated meaningful conversations that would lead to actionable recommendations for relevant institutions.

The project's outcomes include a comprehensive list of recommendations addressing the identified challenges. These recommendations serve as a roadmap for institutions to address issues related to gender equality and advance the agenda of women's empowerment in the region. Focusing on media, dialogue, and collaboration, the project aimed to support women's efforts in building regional democracy.

27. THE GREEN VALLEY



**A project led by IPSIA
BiH, based in Sarajevo.**

**With partners,
Volonterski centar
Vojvodine in Novi Sad
and GAIA in Prishtina.**

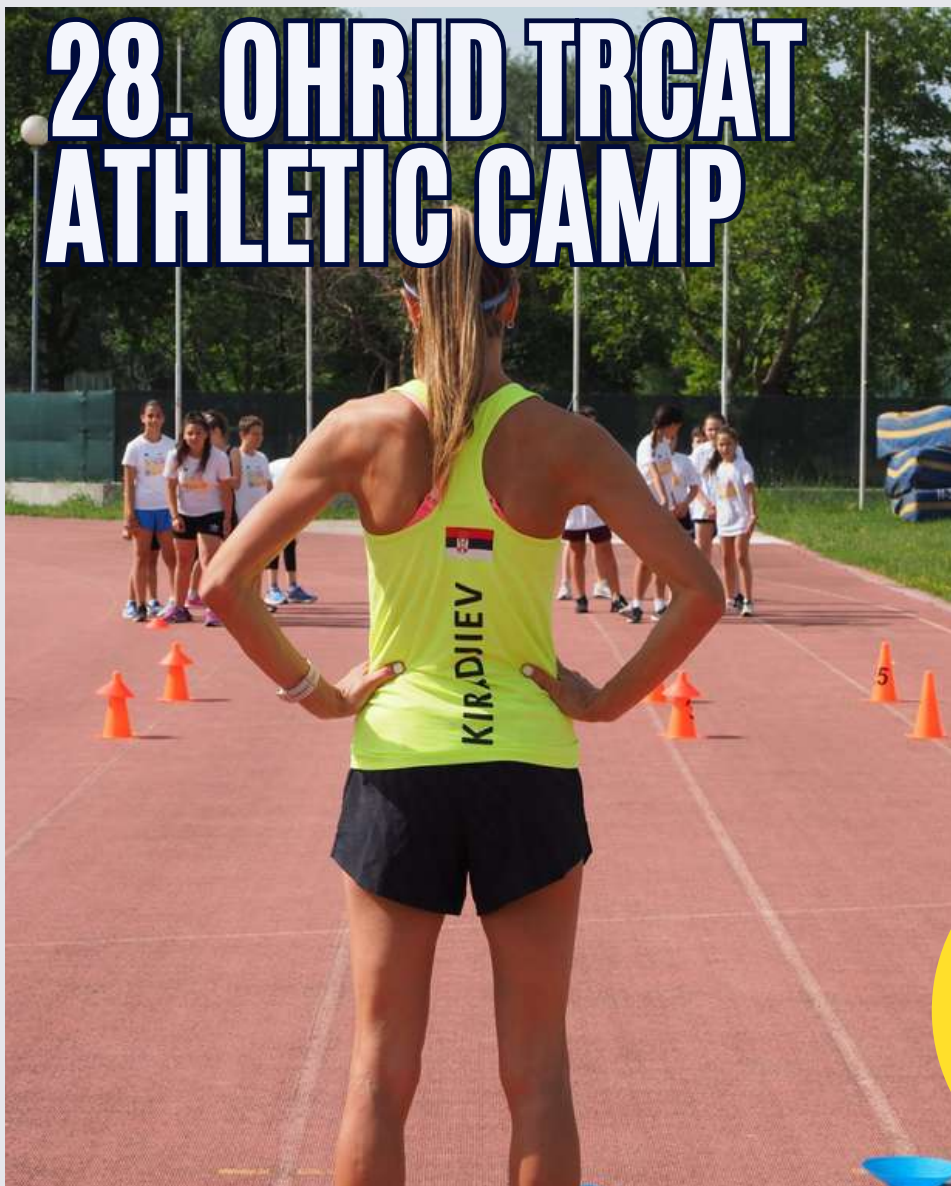
**Activities took place
in Sarajevo, Novi Sad
and Prishtina.**

The Green Valley project aimed to address the importance of biodiversity and promote tourism while raising awareness about the dangers of biodiversity loss. It focused on collaboration among non-governmental organizations, advancing knowledge on migratory bird species in the Western Balkan region, and empowering young individuals to actively engage in environmental conservation. By promoting collaboration among NGOs, the project sought to enhance collective efforts in biodiversity conservation.

The project also focused on advancing knowledge about migratory bird species in the region. By studying and understanding their behaviors, habitats, and migration patterns, the project aimed to contribute to their conservation and promote the importance of protecting their habitats. One of the significant aspects of the project was empowering young individuals through active engagement in environmental conservation efforts. With the involvement of students from diverse CPs, nationalities, and religious backgrounds, the project fostered a sense of shared purpose and reconciliation.

It provided opportunities for young people to contribute to conservation efforts and develop a sense of responsibility towards their environment. The project embraced inclusivity and equality, with equal participation and gender balance and ensured equal representation and participation of both genders, the project promoted gender equality and recognized the importance of diverse perspectives in addressing environmental challenges.

28. OHRID TRCAT ATHLETIC CAMP



A project led by Athletic Club Ohrid Trcat in Ohrid.

With partners, Association Zdrav Zivot-Kinezis in Mostar; Trail Running Albania in Tirana; AK Hajduk-Maraton Tim Kula in Kula and AK Rabotnicki in Skopje.

Activities took place in Ohrid.



The project "Children's Engagement in Democracy" focused on actively engaging children in democratic processes and fostering their understanding of democracy from an early age. The project recognizes that democracy is a concept that children can gradually learn and develop as they grow, and it emphasizes the importance of their participation in their homes, schools, and communities. The project brought together 60 children for a week-long sports camp in Ohrid, providing them with opportunities to participate and contribute to decision-making processes.

The project went beyond formal structures and highlights the significance of the relational context in which children develop their understanding of democracy where they promoted notions of competence and voice, the project supports children's participation and empowers them to express their opinions and beliefs. Through various activities and interactions, the project acknowledges and facilitates children's informal and social involvement in democratic processes. Importantly, the project recognizes that children can initiate new democratic processes themselves.

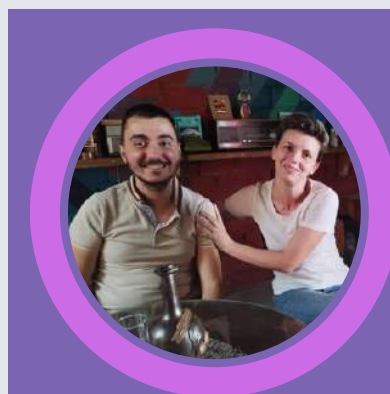
29. YOUTH ARTISANAL CENTRE

The regional initiative aimed to unite and empower individuals with disabilities through comprehensive training in artisanal work, fostering their economic self-reliance and overall well-being. The acquired skills not only empowered them but also enabled them to contribute to their families and communities, instilling a sense of pride and accomplishment. The project went beyond individual empowerment by creating a network of individuals with disabilities across the region.

This network served as a platform for collaboration, support, and advocacy, with the overarching goal of promoting the rights and inclusion of people with disabilities.

Through shared experiences, knowledge exchange, and joint initiatives, the network became a powerful force in breaking down barriers and challenging societal perceptions. The project nurtured their inherent talents and providing opportunities for artistic and artisanal expression, and not only enhanced their skills but also helped them discover their true potential.

Ultimately, the project managed to create a more inclusive society by empowering individuals with disabilities, promoting their economic independence, and fostering their active participation in their families, communities, and society as a whole.



A project led by
Association Tirana
Ekspres.

With partners, Artlab
in Sarajevo and NGO
Creative and Active in
Struga.

Activities took place in Tirana, Mostar and Struga.

30. STRENGTHENING INTERCULTURAL DIALOGUE AS A TOOL FOR YOUTH-TO-YOUTH CONNECTION

A project led by Albanian Foundation for Conflict Resolution and Reconciliation of Disputes in Tirana.

With partners, Association Interactive Education and Resource Network - IMOR in Bitola and Nansen Dialogue Centre Mostar.

Activities took place in Tirana, Durrës, Mostar, Prilep and Bitola.



Reconciliation and Peace were at heart of the students exchange partnership implemented by the AFCR and partners.

By targeting reconciliation and peace, the projects aimed at promoting intercultural dialogue as a means of building good neighbourly relations.

For over six months, thanks to the project, three leading high schools, the “Petro Nini Luarasi” in Tirana, Gimnazija Mostar and “Orde Chopela” in Prilep established a fruitful and rotating exchange system between their students.

Relying in the creativity of over 300 students included, the collaborative approach produced long-lasting art, including paintings, drawings and essays highlighting the diversity, respect and mutual collaboration between the teenagers. The project concluded with a final Conference in Durrës.

The approach of this project contributed towards strengthening regional cooperation and youth to youth cooperation, thus enhancing the regional cohesion between the respective Contracting Parties of the Fund.

The Joint Action Continues...

The 5th Call for Proposals within the grant scheme of the Western Balkans Fund/European Union Joint Action awarded 36 grants to 127 Civil Society Organisations (CSOs) in December 2022. This overall objective of the Call was to improve cooperation and enhance reconciliation at the regional level in the Western Balkans. The awarded grants focused on various fields of intervention, including culture, education, science and research, sustainable development, environmental issues, and women empowerment. With a total budget of 500,000 Euros, up to 15,000 Euros were awarded per project, making it the largest Call in the history of the Western Balkans Fund. For the 5th Call for Proposals, several new features were introduced. |

The Call began with a regional Information Session –Tour that took place in two destinations per Contracting Party, engaging with stakeholders in cities such as Belgrade, Nis, Prishtina, Mitrovica, Skopje, Tetovo, Tirana, Shkodër, Podgorica, Niksic, Sarajevo, and Tuzla. In addition, Info Days were organized for the first time, allowing visits to additional destinations and the engagement of new stakeholders

A notable addition for the grantees of the 5th Call was the implementation of a fully automated online reporting system. Grantees were provided access to Online Grant Management System, offering a streamlined and user-friendly reporting process available 24/7. This system aims to enhance convenience and accessibility for the grantees. The success of the online application system from the 4th Call for Proposals was also replicated, allowing applicants to submit their proposals online. The online application system utilizes a sophisticated platform that promotes transparency and accountability throughout the process. The adoption of the automated online reporting system and the continuation of the online application system represents significant advancements in the procedures of the Western Balkans Fund. These digital tools have streamlined the application and reporting processes, improving the overall efficiency and effectiveness of the grant management system. Grantees now have greater flexibility and convenience in reporting their progress, while applicants benefit from a transparent and accountable application process.

Awarded Regional Projects of the Second Call for Proposals (logo of the lead-applicants)





Teaser of the activities currently under implementation from the 5th Call for Proposals. The timeline for implementation commenced on 1 January 2023 and the 36 projects must close their project and report within the end of October 2023.





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